To understand the earth biomes, it is necessary to understand the following:

1. The characteristics of regional climate.
2. Aspects of the physical environment.
3. The type of soil and the processes contributing to soil development.
4. The distribution of flora in the area.
5. The distribution of fauna in the area and their adaptation to the environment.

## A. Aquatic Biomes

The aquatic biomes are the most important of all the biomes as, the water forms the vital resource and is essential for any life form. Since many types of species live in the water, it is one of the most important natural resources that need to be protected.

Aquatic Biome is further divided into:

a. Fresh Water Biome and
b. Marine Biome

### a. Fresh Water Biome

These biomes are spread over all parts of the earth and have different set of species depending on their location and climate. Fresh water biomes include areas of ponds, lakes, streams, rivers and wetlands. Lakes and ponds are stagnant water bodies and are smaller in their area. The diversity of life forms in river changes with increasing water volume. For example, Dolphins are found in the river Ganges, Brahmaputra and the Indus which carry huge volumes of water.

### b. Marine Biome

Marine biome is an aquatic biome which is salt water biome occupying seas and oceans of the world. Marine biome plants have various roles, plants such as sea grasses and macro algae give shelter and nutrient for many animals.

Marine plants are sources of nutrients for the corals and help corals to build up reefs. The reefs are kept intact by plants like coralline algae.



**Coral Reefs**

Corals are marine invertebrates which live in compact colonies. They inhabit tropical oceans and seas. Corals grow optimally in temperatures between 23°C and 29° C but corals cannot survive in waters below 20°C.Coral reefs are marine ecosystems which are held together by structures made of calcium carbonate secreted by the corals. Coral reefs are mainly classified into three types – Fringing reef, Barrier reef and Atoll .



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